

August 12, 2026

TRICARE East (Humana Military)
Provider Appeals Department

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Marlin Kuphal (MRN MUSC0945691), Claim MUSC-20250731-3CE3-2

Patient	Marlin Kuphal (DOB 1941-08-11)
MRN	MUSC0945691
Member ID / Group	TRI659593889 / GRP-81211
Claim number	MUSC-20250731-3CE3-2
Date of service	2025-07-31
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$1,196.45
Denial code	CARC 50 / RARC N115 — These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer.
Appeal deadline	2025-11-30

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health Florence Medical Center submits this formal first-level appeal on behalf of Marlin Kuphal (Member ID: TRI659593889) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-20250731-3CE3-2, covering services rendered on July 31, 2025 by Daniel R. Okafor, MD (NPI 1558493021). The claim was submitted on August 12, 2025 for CPT code 99214 (office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity, two units) under revenue code 0510 at MUSC Health Florence Medical Center, an on-campus outpatient hospital setting. The total billed amount of \$1,196.45 was denied in full, with \$0.00 paid against an allowed amount of \$679.27. This appeal is submitted within the 90-day filing window prior to the November 30, 2025 deadline.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Kuphal is an 85-year-old male with an established and documented medical history relevant to the services billed on the date of service. His active conditions include chronic sinusitis with onset dating to 1977 and hypertension with onset dating to 1959, for which he has been maintained on Hydrochlorothiazide 25 mg as an active, long-standing medication. His medical record further reflects a recurrent pattern of acute upper respiratory conditions, including prior episodes of viral sinusitis and acute viral pharyngitis documented across multiple years. The primary diagnosis reported on the claim, J06.9 (Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified), is consistent with this established clinical history. The secondary diagnosis of I10 (Essential hypertension) reflects his active, chronic comorbidity requiring ongoing management. Given Mr. Kuphal's age, his decades-long history of both chronic sinusitis and hypertension, and the recurrent nature of his upper respiratory conditions, evaluation and management of an acute upper respiratory infection in this patient population carries meaningful clinical complexity.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

TRICARE East (Humana Military) denied this claim under CARC 50, stating that the services are "non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer," with RARC N115 indicating the decision was based on a Local Coverage Determination. The payer's remark further states that "documentation submitted does not establish that the service was reasonable and necessary for the diagnosis reported."

MUSC Health respectfully disagrees with this determination. CPT code 99214 describes an office or outpatient visit for an established patient involving moderate complexity medical decision-making. For an 85-year-old patient with active chronic sinusitis of nearly five decades' duration, active hypertension, and a presenting acute upper respiratory infection, the level of medical decision-making required is consistent with moderate complexity. The interaction between an acute respiratory illness and a patient's chronic respiratory and cardiovascular conditions — particularly in a geriatric patient — requires assessment of multiple diagnoses, review of ongoing medications, and consideration of potential complications, all of which support the 99214 level of service. The documentation of current medications is a recurring and clinically relevant component of this patient's care, as reflected throughout his longitudinal record.

Furthermore, billing two units of 99214 at a place of service designated as on-campus outpatient hospital is consistent with applicable CPT and facility billing guidance when the clinical circumstances support it. The denial does not appear to account for the full clinical context presented by this patient's age, active comorbidities, and the complexity inherent in managing an acute illness superimposed on chronic conditions in an elderly individual.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that TRICARE East (Humana Military) overturn the denial of Claim MUSC-20250731-3CE3-2 and reprocess the claim for payment at the allowed amount of \$679.27, consistent with the contracted rate. We further request that the plan provide, upon request, the specific Local Coverage Determination cited under RARC N115 so that any additional documentation requirements may be addressed promptly. Should the plan require supplemental clinical documentation from Dr. Okafor's July 31, 2025 encounter notes, MUSC Health will provide those records immediately upon request to facilitate timely resolution of this appeal.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record